pronounced history of leaning towards Pakistan during the Cold War. It was, of course, given to some degree of hyphenation like much of the Western world.

But for reasons rooted in history and culture, there was always a partiality in Japanese politics towards India. Respect for an ancient civilization was widely shared, and the immediate post-War period actually witnessed political warmth between the leaderships. Indian policies conveyed their sympathy for Japan's predicament, and the dissenting voice of Justice Radhabinod Pal at the Tokyo Tribunal was subtly appreciated.

On its part, Japan supported India's socio-economic goals through substantial levels of Official Development Assistance (ODA). Within the Western camp, on a range of issues, it was among the friendlier voices. The paradox of the relationship, in fact, was that the very lack of problems also limited policy attention.

As with many other states, India–Japan ties also felt the implications of what befell India during this period. Economically, a traditionally broad presence of Japanese companies failed to strike deep roots in the absence of a welcoming environment. They gravitated instead to Southeast Asia and, thereafter, to China, lowering India steadily in terms of Japanese priorities. Even when economic reforms were introduced in 1991, the Japanese business community responded with great caution, expressed in a demand that the enabling environment should come up to their expectations.

The thinness of the interface was not limited only to business, it also extended to the supportive activities that Japan normally encouraged. Whether it was education, culture or travel, the two nations continued to remain distant, even if pleasantly. The political domain was not helpful in this period either. There were already the compulsions of the Cold War that pulled the two countries in opposing directions. India's defeat in 1962 in the border conflict with China had obviously damaged its standing as well, and its economic struggles thereafter strengthened a negative stereotype.

Sometimes, situations get worse before getting better. This happened in the instant case when India's nuclear tests in 1998 shook the ties out of their complacency. It is understandable, given its history, that Japan should react strongly to that development. What was, however, perplexing to the Indian side was its sweeping disregard of the security compulsions of the other party. This was aggravated by the fact that Japan had not hesitated to ensure its own security through a treaty arrangement with a nuclear power.